

Episode 190: *Mawaru Penguindrum* Colour Design Notes – Part 17

"♪London, London, your London~" Huh? There used to be a commercial like that, right? It somehow stuck in my ear so I ended up writing it, but what commercial was that exactly? (sweat) National? Tokyo local? Hmm...

Well, anyway, it's the London Olympics (laugh).

Whether summer or winter, what I look forward to every Olympics is the opening ceremony. Man, that's amazing. It's a grand show created by requesting famous artists and directors to direct it, staking the nation's prestige. For us making anime, it's must-see. Especially for us colour-related people, it's must-see. The various spatial and colour direction performances unfolding three-dimensionally in that vast space - man, it's very educational every time!

Even for individual competitions, the arrangement and colour schemes of various things in the venues, the art design is worth watching too. The unified design sense maintained throughout the entire event. Not just "Go Japan!" but I try to watch the Olympics with such a perspective.

Oh yes, compared to the previous Beijing Olympics, this London event feels like the overall colouring design is put together more chic. Ah, that's national character, or regional differences - hmm, interesting.

Oh, and go for it! Japan!

Now then.

So we *Penguindrum* site staff ended up making a new opening after all, but schedule-wise starting from Episode 13 was definitely impossible! So when content-wise would it be okay to make it new? After all, the opening is the programmes's face. To change that face, there really needs to be appropriate timing. Originally Episode 13, switching from

first to second half, would be one timing, but well, we couldn't make that deadline, so when would the next timing be?

So, we ultimately decided to make the new opening from Episode 15! That timing was probably the last timing. So we rushed into work toward that goal.

But before that, Episode 14.

Episode 14: "Lying Princess" Storyboard/Ikuhara Kunihiko & Yamazaki Mitsue, Direction/Yamazaki Mitsue, Colour Direction/Akimoto Yuki

Ringo, whose relationship with Shoma has become strained, thinks about somehow recovering their relationship, but Shoma's reaction is cold, and she sinks to the bottom of despair. Tokikago Yuri approaches her. Taking Ringo into her private car, she plans a hot spring trip for just the two of them. Yuri and Ringo, and when their feelings have quite opened up that night, Yuri mysteriously approaches Ringo to make her hers. Such was Episode 14.

Anyway, I think Episode 14 was shocking in various ways for everyone watching weekly (grin).

This Episode 14 - what was difficult in various ways first was Yuri's car. Of course a foreign car, a Jaguar. This used 3DCG entirely. I think we purchased a ready-made 3D model and used that as the base. Since "there's no one among current rough animation forces who can draw mecha, it'd be impossible," we had no plans to draw automobiles with animation from the beginning. The truck speeding through rain in Episode 5 was also 3DCG, based on the same thinking. Not only is it difficult to do with animation, but there are actually many failures, so when you think about it, this kind of thing should be 3DCG!

For that car, what first concerned us was its texture. If you place it on screen with a look that's too realistically 3D, the worldview breaks at that moment. So "how much 3D-ness would be okay?" was an important point to explore. How much 3D-ness would be acceptable was really a matter of our sensory balance. So rather than super-smooth glossy 3D, we requested adjustment from the start toward cel-shading that brought the atmosphere closer to animation. Then it was a matter of how much to adjust that degree.

So, for that exterior car body colour tone, this decision was quite difficult. Actually, I wanted to make this car "champagne gold." In my mind, Tokikago Yuri's image was somehow "champagne gold," so I really wanted to make this car champagne gold. "Champagne gold" is quite difficult to do with regular animation, and I felt like we couldn't create or show the subtle colour reflections beautifully, so ah, with 3DCG we could probably do it properly and beautifully.

However, this didn't go as smoothly as I thought.

When we focused on properly expressing the "champagne gold" feeling and built up the surface texture, it inevitably became a floating presence on screen. Also, the stronger we made the shading for balance with animation, the more it just looked like a cream-coloured painted body. In this way, I asked 3D staff Kaneko to work hard on adjustments many, many times, but we couldn't get that decisive "this is it!" and only time passed. So we decided on the red body that had been prepared as a backup plan. It was honestly a last-minute decision due to insufficient work time. Ugh, disappointing!

So, the red car.

For the scene of that car driving at night on the Metropolitan Expressway, we leaned the 3D expression somewhat excessively toward realism, with reflections of Metropolitan Expressway lighting and such. As I wrote earlier, considering compatibility with animation, we had 3D as cel-shading, but for this scene rather, the realistic direction would better match Yuri's emotional state, so we deliberately did that.

Incidentally, while the exterior is completely a 3D model, for the car interior we had 3D provide layout and had rough animation drawn according to that guide. In other words, hybrid animation. Additionally, we had it nicely built up with special effects.

Like that Metropolitan Expressway scene, this episode basically created each scene matching the spatial brightness and colour tone. Hotel guest rooms, open-air baths, hot spring ping-pong, dining scenes in guest rooms - I built up colour tone and brightness for each to match the background lighting conditions.

The theatres scene before the opening was based on Episode 7's cuts and processing, adding even more. By this point in the episode count, there were many scenes in the same places used previously, and for such scenes we aimed for labour savings by using layouts from previously appearing cuts as much as possible at the storyboard stage, and using the same backgrounds when possible. With background art of such content volume, the work burden every episode was considerable, and moreover the art team's available time was being gradually shaved due to animation schedule delays. But this labour-saving was simultaneously a very useful technique for "imprinting" scenes and places.

Now, the problem nudity (laugh).

This time's director was Assistant Director Yamazaki Mitsue, who calls herself "Penguindrum's ero person in charge" (true story (laugh)). A-part's Yuri, B-part's hot springs and rooms. Man, what can I say (laugh). Especially the B-part hot spring inn was Animation Director Ishii Kumi's part if I remember correctly, and it was really good - I was quite excited while creating the screen (laugh).

Create the atmosphere to the limit but don't show. Under such tacit understanding, this episode also didn't show to the limit (laugh). That's also why there was the towel wrap in

the open-air bath. Certainly, in actual hot springs you shouldn't enter the bath with a towel wrapped, but well, that's how it is.

For the final bedroom passage after the mysterious atmosphere began, I created colours with two things in mind: first, make the skin look beautiful, and second, create mysterious tension on screen as a "hook" to the next episode. Initially thinking "make skin beautiful," I created and shot colour tones that showed skin colour fairly directly, but it became too raw and I couldn't create the scene well. So after all rushes I had it retaken, creating shadow colours with purple mixed in. I searched for just the right purple feeling for the bedroom's blue space, actually painted it in the cut, and finally completed the decision. Those are that scene's colour tones.

"Rather than blending with the screen, make it clearly red, bright red with a sharp impact!" These were words I said to colour director Akimoto during the colour direction meeting. "This will decide this episode (laugh)." It was explaining the cut where naked Yuri mysteriously goes "sharp!" with the red cord (laugh).

(12.07.31)